

Bolo Bill — voice-first billing for Indian retail

Pre-seed · ₹60 lakh · Chennai · Karthik Srinivasan, solo founder · bolo-bill.vercel.app — the product is live and you can try it

A doctor should be looking at the patient, not the screen. A retailer should be looking at the customer, not the gadget. Every billing system built for Indian retail asks the shopkeeper to look away — find an item, type a quantity, fix a typo — while a customer waits. So the shops that can least afford it keep the notebook, and 88% of Indian retail remains unorganised trade.

Bolo Bill removes the interface. The shopkeeper speaks — in Tamil, Hindi, Malayalam, Telugu, Kannada or English, code-mixed the way people actually talk — and the bill assembles line by line, ending in a UPI QR for the exact amount and a numbered GST-compliant receipt. It runs on the phone they already own plus a ₹2,500 printer, against the ₹9,990–37,000 billing machines this market is otherwise sold.

What exists — a working product, not a mockup

Live and in use at **Ragas Coffee**, a working café: **~50 bills over one week**, and within that week the operator moved from press-to-talk to the hands-free wake word. Six languages, multi-item dictation in one breath, per-shop spoken aliases, confidence gating, gapless receipt numbering, WhatsApp delivery. **1,561 automated tests**, including a 1,003-case matrix across five languages. Built solo, on no outside capital.

The insight underneath the speed

The café's owner **does not know objectively what margin he makes**. He is not unusual — owners have neither the time nor the training to read a dashboard, so understanding of their own business is outsourced to an auditor once a quarter. So the same idea that removes typing from billing also removes the spreadsheet from knowing your numbers: *ask the shop a question aloud, get an answer aloud*. That is a Tier-1 module here, not a Tier-2 dashboard, and it is the clearest unmet need we have observed first-hand.

Business model — priced against what the shop already pays

₹399/month for a single counter. Ragas pays WeP **₹583/month** in annual maintenance today, on top of sunk capex, for a machine that cannot tell him his margin — **that** is the reference price, not a free tier. ₹1,999 for 2–10 outlets, undercutting Petpooja's reported ₹3,000–12,000 band. Hardware kit sold at cost, never at margin: we do not manufacture, hold stock, or touch payment funds.

The number this business turns on, stated plainly

On cloud ASR a typical shop is **–₹358/month gross**. Moving inference on-device takes the same shop to **+₹362 at 91% margin** — LTV ₹9,050, CAC ₹800, **11.3× LTV:CAC**, payback 2.2 months. Break-even on cloud is **₹0.0603 per utterance**; above that, Tier 1 cannot be profitable at any volume. **That is what this round is for — moving inference on-device, not adding features.**

Why it is defensible after ASR commoditises

It will, and that is fine — voice recognition is not the moat. The moat is the **per-shop alias catalog** (each shop teaches the system its own words; after a month it knows *this* shop's "aloo" is *that* SKU — switching cost the shop built themselves) and the **corrected-utterance corpus**, which is the only realistic route to an on-device model tuned to code-mixed retail speech. The moat and the cost structure are the same asset.

What is not proven — said here rather than found later

- **Offline billing does not exist yet.** Against Vyapar that is a disqualification, not a gap. It is the first thing this round buys.
- **Nobody but the founder has spoken to the system.** Accent and noise testing used synthetic voices.
- **Retention is unknown.** One week at one shop. The 4%/month churn in the model is its weakest number.
- **The on-device ASR target is unvalidated.** If a small quantised model cannot hit accuracy on code-mixed retail speech, pricing has to move. It is spiked in months 1–3, before headcount.

The ask

₹60 lakh pre-seed, backed out of an 18-month plan rather than rounded: ₹36L engineering (one ASR/Android engineer — the on-device port *is* the round), ₹12L field and onboarding, ₹8L infrastructure and devices, ₹4L buffer. Founder unpaid in Year 1. It buys four things: offline billing, inference on-device and under break-even, ten retained shops, and measured error and churn — which is what turns a working prototype into a fundable business.

Faster than paper, or it does not ship.

Every figure traces to the unit-economics model or to observed data at the design partner. Market figures: Mordor Intelligence (POS), public industry sources (kirana counts, competitor pricing). Competitor pricing spot-checked August 2026; Petpooja does not publish rates.